

His Fictitious Beloved

And here again with bright silks flying like banners from red palace windows was Sikri, shimmering in the heat like an opium vision. Here at last with its strutting peacocks and dancing girls was home. If the war-torn world was a harsh truth then Sikri was a beautiful lie. The emperor came home like a smoker returning to his pipe. He was the Enchanter. In this place he would conjure a new world, a world beyond religion, region, rank and tribe. The most beautiful women in the world were here and they were all his wives. The most brilliant talents in the land were assembled here, among them the Nine Stars, the nine most brilliant of the most brilliant, and with their help there was nothing he could not accomplish. With their help his wizardry would magick all the land, and the future, and all eternity. An emperor was a bewitcher of the real, and with such accomplices his witchcraft could not fail. The songs of Tansen could break open the seals of the universe and let divinity through into the everyday world. The poems of Faizi opened windows in the heart and mind through which both light and darkness could be seen. The governance of Raja Man Singh and the financial skills of Raja Todar Mal meant the empire's business was in the best of hands. And then there was Birbal, the best



of the nine who were the best of the best. His first minister, and first friend.

The first minister and greatest wit of the age greeted him at the Hiran Minar, the tower of elephants' teeth. The emperor's sense of mischief was aroused. 'Birbal,' Akbar said, dismounting from his horse, 'will you answer me one question? We have been waiting a long time to ask it.' The first minister of legendary wit and wisdom bowed humbly. 'As you wish, *Jahanpanah*, Shelter of the World.' 'Well then,' said Akbar, 'which came first, the chicken or the egg?' Birbal replied at once, 'The chicken.' Akbar was taken aback. 'How can you be so sure?' he wanted to know. 'Huzoor,' Birbal replied, 'I only promised to answer one question.'

The first minister and the emperor were standing on the ramparts of the city looking out at the wheeling crows. 'Birbal,' Akbar mused, 'how many

crows do you imagine there are in my kingdom?' '*Jahanpanah*,' Birbal replied, 'there are exactly nine hundred and ninety-nine thousand, nine hundred and ninety-nine.' 'Akbar was puzzled. 'Suppose we have them counted,' he said, 'and there are more than that, what then?' 'That would mean,' Birbal replied, 'that their friends from the neighbouring kingdom have come to visit them.' 'And if there are fewer?' 'Then some of ours will have gone abroad

"The emperor had put her together, they fumed, by stealing bits of them all. He said she was the daughter of the prince of Jodhpur. She was not!"

